

Start Up Studio: Interview Questions

Conducted by Abraham Alemu

Omega Zerfu - Idea 2

Pain Points:

- He wants activities to work well whether he is going out by himself or with a group.
- He wants to maximize the value of new experiences, travel, and purchases.
- Cost and overall happiness both affect whether an experience feels worthwhile.
- Transportation can make it harder to follow through on an activity or destination.

Potential Solutions:

- Reduce transportation friction so getting to a place is easier.
- Help users compare options based on cost and overall value.
- Make the experience fast and simple enough to use while making plans.

Magic Wand:

- The product would have essentially zero latency.
- The interface would be extremely user-friendly.
- It would reduce the total cost of going out while still maximizing the experience.

Handakina Tsegaye - Idea 2

Pain Points:

- She gets frustrated when trying to follow directions.
- Street signs and the way Google Maps or Apple Maps present directions can be confusing.
- When she gets lost, she sometimes relies on people who know the area or asks random people for help.
- She is not very outgoing and does not regularly try new places.

Potential Solutions:

- Combine discovery of TikTok food spots with easier navigation to those locations.
- Streamline reviews so it is faster to judge whether a place is worth visiting.
- Make directions more intuitive for someone who does not go out often.

Magic Wand:

- Show navigation through an angled, walking-point-of-view map instead of a traditional overhead map.
- Make the route visually obvious enough that she does not need to ask other people for directions.

Eden Abebe - idea 2

Pain Points:

- She can have trouble figuring out the correct subway station when going somewhere.
- Planning the details of an outing can feel like extra work.
- Cost matters when deciding what activities are actually worth doing.

Potential Solutions:

- Provide recommendations with ratings from more people so she can compare options confidently.
- Use a familiar Google Maps-like interface for discovery and navigation.
- Surface cost-effective options that help her stretch her budget.

Magic Wand:

- Automatically create an itinerary instead of making her plan the outing herself.
- Build the itinerary around affordable recommendations and straightforward transportation.

Conducted by Jaden Hinton

Yabby Maelaf

Pain Points:

- She saves dozens of TikToks and Instagram posts about restaurants and pop-ups but rarely goes back to the folder when she actually has free time.
- She likes being the friend who finds new places first, and it bothers her when she shows up somewhere after it has already peaked.
- Planning across multiple apps (TikTok for ideas, Maps for directions, group chat for coordination) makes spontaneous outings feel slower than they should.
- She often ends up at the same few spots because they are the easiest to remember in the moment.
- Saved videos rarely include the exact address, so she has to dig through comments to find where a place is.
- She gets bored quickly and wants a steady stream of new things to try each weekend.
- When she travels, she spends the first day just figuring out which neighborhoods are worth exploring.
- Friends ask her for recommendations constantly, and she has no easy way to share her running list.

Potential Solutions:

- Pull saved posts into one map so her ideas are tied to actual locations.
- Show what is trending right now in her area so she can catch places early.
- Let her share a spot or a route with friends directly from the map.

Magic Wand:

- Open the app on a Saturday afternoon and instantly see a live heat map of what is popping within a 20 minute radius.
- Get a notification when a place she saved starts trending nearby.

Genna Gonzaga - idea 2

Pain Points:

- Popular spots feel crowded and overhyped, and she gets frustrated when a place she loved goes viral and changes.
- Most recommendation apps push the same high-rated chains and tourist favorites instead of smaller, niche places.
- She does not want to scroll through loud, influencer-style videos just to find a quiet café or bookstore.
- She prefers going out alone or with one friend, so group-focused planning tools do not fit her.
- She never knows how busy a place will be until she arrives.
- Reviews from large crowds do not reflect her taste, so high ratings are not always helpful.

Potential Solutions:

- Let users filter the heat map in reverse to find places that are well-reviewed but not crowded.
- Surface niche categories like independent bookstores, listening bars, and small galleries.
- Offer a calm, minimal browsing mode without autoplay video.
- Show reviews from people with similar preferences.

Magic Wand:

- A "hidden gems" layer that shows spots loved by a small group of people with similar taste, before they blow up.
- Real-time crowd levels so she can go when a place is quiet.

Kishanti Barmoh

Pain Points:

- She loves communal spaces like food halls, markets, and parks, but finding events happening that day takes a lot of searching.
- Group plans often fall apart because no one commits to a specific place or time.
- She sends posts to friends with "we need to go here" messages that never turn into actual outings.
- Information about free community events is scattered across Instagram stories, flyers, and Eventbrite.
- By the time she hears about a street fair or pop-up market, it has often already ended.
- It is hard to pick a spot that works for a group with different budgets and tastes.
- She wants to meet new people but does not know where social, welcoming crowds tend to gather.

Potential Solutions:

- Combine popular places and live community events on the same map.
- Turn a shared post into a group plan with a time, location, and RSVP.

- Highlight free or low-cost gathering spots.

Magic Wand:

- See where people are gathering right now, like a busy market or a park with live music, and invite friends with one tap.
- A shared group map where everyone's saves show up together so the group can agree on a plan quickly.

Leon Huang - idea 2

Pain Points:

- He values quality, atmosphere, and exclusivity, and most review platforms mix casual spots with high-end ones in a way that wastes his time.
- Star ratings do not tell him whether a place has the refinement he is looking for.
- Reservations at the places he wants are hard to get, and he often learns about openings too late.
- Viral popularity does not always mean a place is good, and he does not trust hype on its own.
- Once a refined spot becomes trendy online, the crowd and experience often decline.

Potential Solutions:

- Separate trending popularity from curated quality signals so he can judge both.
- Filter by experience level, such as fine dining, cocktail bars, galleries, and private events.
- Connect directly to reservation availability.

Magic Wand:

- A curated layer of the heat map showing only refined, well-regarded spots that are gaining attention among people with similar taste.
- Alerts when a reservation opens at a place he has saved.
- A way to tell whether a place's popularity is rising or already fading.

Jaden Barret

Pain Points:

- He wants to be at the top spots in the city, and missing out on the place everyone is talking about feels like a lost opportunity.
- He spends a lot of time cross-checking TikTok, Instagram, and friends to figure out what is actually hot this week.
- Fashion pop-ups, sample sales, and store launches are announced in scattered places and are easy to miss.

- When traveling, he does not know which spots locals consider the best versus what is only popular with tourists.
- Nightlife buzz changes week to week, and last month's hot spot is often dead now.
- He cares about the scene and the crowd, not just the food or drinks, and reviews rarely capture that.
- Lines and guest lists at popular venues are unpredictable.
- He wants to know where people with similar style are going, not just what is broadly popular.
- He likes posting where he goes, so he wants places that feel current and worth sharing.

Potential Solutions:

- Rank spots by real-time buzz so he can see what is hottest right now.
- Include retail drops, pop-ups, and fashion events alongside restaurants and nightlife.
- Show what is trending with locals versus tourists in a new city.
- Display live wait times or line estimates.

Magic Wand:

- One map that shows the most talked-about restaurants, stores, and events in any city, updated live.
- A "where to be tonight" view he can check before going out.

Keller Patterson

Pain Points:

- His football schedule leaves him very little free time, so when he does get a free day he wants it to count.
- He does not travel much and has no idea what is worth visiting when he finally gets a chance.
- Researching a new place takes time he does not have, and he often defaults to whatever is closest.
- Team travel puts him in new cities briefly, but he rarely knows what is good near the hotel.
- His free time often comes at odd hours, like late evenings after practice, when many places are closed.
- He is usually tired after training and does not want to travel far to get somewhere.
- He has a strict diet during the season, so not every viral food spot fits.
- Teammates usually decide plans, and he rarely gets to try places he picked himself.
- He does not use social media heavily, so he misses a lot of what is trending.
- He is not familiar with transit in new cities and worries about wasting limited time getting lost.

Potential Solutions:

- Show the best options near his current location instantly, with no research required.
- Filter by how much time he has, such as one hour, an afternoon, or a full day.
- Highlight places that are popular, open now, and easy to reach.
- Filter food spots by healthier or high-protein options.

Magic Wand:

- Drop into any city and immediately see the top spots within walking distance on a heat map.
- Get a ready-made short itinerary that fits the exact window of free time he has.

Joshua Pacho

Pain Points:

- He watches tons of food content but loses track of which spots he wanted to try.
- He loves arcades, board game cafés, and gaming bars, but they are hard to find because they are not well categorized on maps.
- Food and activity are usually searched separately, which makes it hard to plan an outing that combines both.
- Prices on viral food spots are often unclear until he arrives.
- Viral dishes sometimes sell out or get discontinued before he gets there.
- He does not know which gaming spots are busy enough to find people to play with.

Potential Solutions:

- Auto-save food spots from TikTok and Instagram directly to a map.
- Create clear categories for gaming venues and activity spots.
- Show nearby food and activities together, with price ranges visible upfront.

Magic Wand:

- A food and fun heat map that shows trending eats next to arcades and game spots so he can plan a full night in seconds.
- A "near my saves" feature that tells him when he is close to a place he saved.